# “We always stay like sisters”: A study exploring empowerment through the lived experiences of marginalised women in Uganda’s skilling programmes.

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**Abstract**

This study explores how women who live in informal settlements in Kampala, Uganda, experience empowerment through Kids Club Kampala's skilling programme in tailoring and knitting. Whilst mainstream development discourse often defines empowerment through an instrumental lens, with a heavy focus on predefined economic outcomes, this research implements a postcolonial feminist theoretical framework to recentre marginalised women's lived experiences and demonstrate the limitations of the mainstream approach. Data was collected through the facilitation of Kids Club Kampala, consisting of semi-structured interviews, a focus group, a key informant interview, and fieldwork observation. The findings reveal that whilst the skilling programme aided in the acquisition of a skill and an increased income, structural barriers remained prevalent, such as financial constraints, time poverty, domestic burden, and institutional limitations. However, the study highlights how important relational empowerment truly is, with the findings demonstrating how an increase in confidence, pride, self-worth, sisterhood, and community solidarity was all key in their empowerment journeys. It was discovered that peer-to-peer knowledge transfer and collective support, such as women's banking groups, provided an alternative perspective of empowerment, one that rejects the neoliberal emphasis on productivity and individualism. This dissertation thus argues that empowerment should not be viewed through narrow economic outcomes, but instead, understood as a relational process that is rooted within a culturally specific context and collective solidarity. It argues that marginalised women's voices should be central to their knowledge production, and an instrumentalist approach to empowerment should be abandoned in favour of real structural change for the women's lives.

**Acronyms**

KCK – Kids Club Kampala

NGO – Non-Government Organisation

UN – United Nations

## Chapter 1: Introduction

Empowerment is observed as an essentially contested concept (Gram, Morrison and Skordis-Worrall, 2018). According to the United Nations, empowerment is defined as "an iterative process with key components including an enabling environment that encourages popular participation in decision-making that affects the achievements of goals like poverty eradication, [...] as well as sustainable development." (United Nations Social Development Network, 2012) Yet this emphasis on women's empowerment as an achievable outcome of increased economic growth has led to the word losing its original transformative meaning. This instrumentalist viewpoint of empowerment in mainstream development discourse promotes a Western neoliberal agenda of productivity and growth rather than the socially radical meaning of the word empowerment, rooted in rights and collective action (Eyben and Napier-Moore, 2009).

Looking at empowerment in Uganda provides an insight into the limitations of instrumental empowerment through a postcolonial feminist lens and emphasises the importance of relational empowerment that ensures collective solidarity. Women in Uganda face structural barriers restricting their access to land and resources, capital gain, and the unequal job market (Ssebunya, 2025). To give women an ability to succeed, skill-based development initiatives have grown in popularity with the World Bank explaining that it "can reduce un- and underemployment, increase productivity, and improve standards of living." (World Bank, 2024) However, this narrow neoliberal economic viewpoint threatens to reinforce placing the burden upon women to reduce poverty, as women tend to be overrepresented amongst the extreme poor due to feminisation of poverty, thus they are targets of development programmes, instead of understanding and changing the structural inequalities that led to their poverty (Faulkner, 2019).

This dissertation investigates how empowerment is experienced by marginalised women in Uganda, working in tandem with a Ugandan organisation, Kids Club Kampala, who provide a skill-based training programme in tailoring and knitting to the women living in informal settlements. Utilising the data collected through semi-structured interviews, a focus group, and a key informant interview, this research aims to foreground marginalised women's situated knowledge in how they experience empowerment. Moreover, this dissertation is guided by a postcolonial feminist theoretical framework to reject Western development ideas about empowerment, stop implementing external ideals, and ensure epistemic justice is achieved.

Chapter 2 will delve into the academic literature surrounding this research topic and will discuss the tensions in conceptualising empowerment, structural constraints, instrumental versus transformative empowerment, and women in Uganda. Chapter 3 explains the postcolonial feminist theoretical framework and how it will be implemented throughout this dissertation. Chapter 4 demonstrates the research aims and objectives, with Chapter 5 highlighting the feminist qualitative methodology used. Chapter 6 discusses the findings and analysis of the data collected through three themes: the limitations of instrumental empowerment, the process of transformation, and collective solidarity: relational empowerment. Finally, Chapter 7 will conclude and provide an insight into limitations and future research.

## Chapter 2: Literature Review

### *2.1 Depoliticisation of empowerment in development*

Within development discourse, the concept of empowerment has become popular, providing a goal for mainstream development initiatives to work towards. Yet, there is an evident lack of clarity when delving into what the word means due to assuming that differing measures of female empowerment work hand in hand, thus undermining initiatives that aim to strengthen empowerment through poverty reduction (Anderson, 2022; Hennink et al., 2012). The mainstreaming of the word empowerment arguably has resulted in it losing its original meaning and strategic value, with its roots in the 1980s being utilised to describe feminist grassroots struggles to reject and change unjust and unequal power structures (Cornwall, 2016; Batliwala, 2007). Now the word has become appropriated for innovation and economic growth, ignoring the original socially

transformative meaning, based on rights and collective action (Eyben and Napier-Moore, 2009; Cornwall, 2007).

The loose meaning of the word allows for development actors to implement and impose their preconceived neoliberal frameworks, ideologies, and beliefs, under the guise of 'female empowerment', which results in the depoliticisation of empowerment and neglects the real societal and systemic change that the word stands for, instead focusing on individualistic terms, such as; individual power, productivity, and innovation (Bailey, 2024; Batliwala, 2007). This process of instrumentalisation reflects broader critiques of gender mainstreaming within development, with Lobo (2024) utilising the term 'purple-washing' to describe how NGOs and transnational corporations appropriate feminist struggles for their gain. This is not to achieve true systemic change, but to promote their public image and further legitimise the neoliberal agenda, with women's freedom having to align within an exploitative capitalist system (Lobo, 2024).

This depoliticisation within mainstream development discourse can be demonstrated by the UN Women (2024), who promote the idea of women's economic empowerment in order to achieve gender equality. For example, the UN Women (2024) states that "When more women work, economies grow", which highlights clearly how women's empowerment is not about structural change but instead about how women can be used to further the neoliberal agenda of productivity and innovation. Demonstrating the instrumentalist nature of narrow economic approaches to empowerment, valuing women's empowerment because of what it can do to boost the economy, instead of real justice and rejection of exploitation. This evidently overlooks the deeply patriarchal and capitalist structures that restrict women's liberation, and this marginalises non-economic forms of empowerment, neglecting how real transformation should be about collective, community movement, and political structural change.

### *2.2 Understanding empowerment through power and structural constraints*

Naila Kabeer (1999) contributed heavily to the development of conceptualising women's empowerment, emphasising the importance of recognising and attempting to change the structures and processes that have restricted and denied women the ability to make choices (Kabeer, 1999). This can be further understood by looking at power as capacity produced through social relations and dynamics, with emphasis on enabling social change

(Eyben, Kabeer and Cornwall, 2008). Power is not a material resource that can be possessed or lost; instead, it is a part of all social interactions and structures, which determines the possibility for women to do or imagine doing something (Eyben, Kabeer and Cornwall, 2008). Whilst this framework provides an overall understanding of how empowerment can be applied to women's liberation, NGOs and development programmes can co-opt this to further their neoliberal agenda, ignoring the cross-cultural importance of empowerment, with a tendency to focus on universality. When in reality, the experiences of women across the world are vastly different in cultural, economic, and political contexts, further reinforcing the idea that empowerment should not be defined through preconceived outcomes but should be redefined by the women affected. This conceptualisation of empowerment demonstrates the importance of not measuring empowerment by simplistic metrics or outcomes, but rather emphasising empowerment's complex and multifaceted nature.

However, there is a high tendency within development discourse and programmes to interpret Kabeer's framework of resources, agency, and achievements in what Serene Khader (2018) terms as 'control choice', whereby empowerment is solely focused on the individual ability of women to achieve their aspirations. Importantly, Khader (2018) reiterates the danger of championing the ability for women to make choices without recognising and acknowledging structural oppression, due to the risk of perpetuating the very inequalities that empowerment aims to resist. Khader (2018) further reinforces this idea by arguing that one must acknowledge that making a woman choose among already bad alternatives and being expected to do more can all lead to increased disempowerment. This idea of expecting women to choose and do more leads to disempowerment. With women living in poor conditions, there are always incentives for them to do more, and as such, they perhaps have developed their beliefs and aspirations to such conditions (Khader, 2018). Importantly, Khader (2018) makes the point that poverty is a constant state of unmet needs, and thus, a woman's ability to be free to use their time as they wishes and have the opportunity to have proper rest is in competition with each other. Moreover, there is a common theme of overlap between agency and empowerment, with a regional analysis done in India by Mishra and Tripathi (2011) demonstrating how empowerment does not necessarily lead to autonomy, further reinforcing that increasing women's capability through 'empowerment' does not automatically increase their agency due to structural barriers. This is crucial in aiding an understanding of how mainstream development discourse fails to recognise how it places the burden back on women to lift

themselves out of poverty, through emphasising individual capacity, without real change of the underlying unequal gender structures. Fundamentally, understanding empowerment as an individual and collective process requires a broader and relational approach that moves beyond control-choice to determine female liberation.

*2.3 Instrumentalist or transformative empowerment*

Within development discourse on empowerment, there is a discrepancy between instrumentalist understandings of empowerment and transformative understandings. Instrumentalist approaches, as conceptualised by Cornwall (2016), result in focusing on what women can provide for development rather than how development can aid women. For development programmes, empowerment becomes a means to an end; increased development, with neoliberal outcomes favoured, such as productivity and increased economic growth (Cornwall, 2016). This, according to Cornwall (2016), produces development programmes that are "rolled out over any terrain", and from that process, women's individual and collective empowerment journeys remain unimportant and hidden from mainstream narratives. This further supports the idea that empowerment is not an end destination or a requirement to be fulfilled, but a relational process shaped by power relations and collective action.

Jo Rowlands (1997) questions this instrumentalist approach to empowerment, developing a transformative one through her work, emphasising it as a process, not an outcome. She argues that the process of empowerment can be experienced as deep personal change and development, but additionally, changed behaviour, and that every woman experiences the journey in their different ways (Rowlands, 1997). Furthermore, that collective empowerment runs alongside the personal aspect, and that there is a circular interrelationship within groups of women, and that participation in these groups may further feed into the process of individual empowerment and vice versa (Rowlands, 1997). Crucially, Rowlands (1997) asserts that whilst there is complex diversity within empowerment, there is a 'core' to the process that can apply to different situations. This constitutes as "increases in self-confidence and self-esteem, a sense of agency and of 'self' in a wider context, and a sense of dignidad (being worthy of and having a right to respect from others)" (Rowlands, 1997). Thus, if these key aspects of empowerment are fostered and developed, the self-perception of women will begin to change, and internalised oppression will be opposed (Rowlands, 1997). This conceptualisation provides

a useful framework to understand empowerment and ensures that the relational process is emphasised throughout and reinforces the importance of a context-specific and culturally sensitive approach to empowerment. However, her approach does call for further critical consideration. Whilst she emphasises the necessity of context-specific empowerment, her development of the idea of 'core' aspects of empowerment leans towards universality, with a potential for these core aspects to become imposed Western ideals and risks rejecting what women of different cultures value. Thus, re-centring women's voices in their empowerment becomes ever more vital.

### *2.4 The problem of conceptualising empowerment*

The review of the literature highlights the complex and multi-faceted approach to conceptualising empowerment within development discourse, with tensions demonstrated between the original, politicised, and transformative roots of the concept and its instrumentalisation and depoliticisation in recent years. Scholars, such as Kabeer (1999) and Rowlands (1997), emphasise the importance of a relational process of empowerment, with a focus on observing empowerment as a process and not a means to an end. However, scholars, such as Cornwall (2016) and Batliwala (2007), warn against how the mainstreaming of the concept of empowerment has led to its instrumentalisation in development programmes and loss of the original meaning rooted in grassroots feminist struggles. Other similar studies, such as one done in Laos, Myanmar, and Vietnam, have looked at how women perceive empowerment, finding that their understanding differs in conjunction with their cultural, economic, and social contexts (Völker and Doneys, 2020). Moreover, Doneys, Doane, and Norm's (2019) study on Cambodian women revealed that they do not perceive empowerment purely through individualistic terms but through a community-focused lens. Further demonstrating the multifaceted nature of conceptualising empowerment and reinforcing women's lived experiences over universalised predefined outcomes.

There is a clear understanding and development of theorising empowerment as a relational process involving interpersonal interactions, and additionally individual and collective change (Eyben and Napier-Moore, 2009; Rowlands, 1997). Yet, a gap seems to arise surrounding qualitative studies that demonstrate clearly how the critique of 'control-choice' empowerment, as presented by Khader (2018), is exhibited in real-life situations and experiences of marginalised women. Khader (2018) argues that the burden is placed

upon women to do more and lift themselves out of poverty; however, with no real-life experiences of women to demonstrate this. This research aims to bridge the gap between development initiatives that focus on economic goals and how this can potentially increase the burden on marginalised women in Uganda, and acknowledge how, without wider systemic change, mainstream development 'empowerment' can perpetuate existing constraints.

*2.5 Skills training in development*

In the past 20 years, the idea of skills training has acquired a central role within development discourse and programming, as observed through the 2015 Sustainable Development Goals, particularly SDG4: quality education (Brown and Neve, 2023). Subsequently, there has been a significant increase in skill development programme investments by transnational institutions in the global South (Brown and Neve, 2023). However, the justification for championing skill development is intrinsically tied to neoliberal broader macroeconomic policies, with a process-oriented outlook of empowerment, emphasising individualism (Carrick-Hagenbarth, 2021). Namely, the United Nations (2023) reiterates that decent education will lead to a boost in quality of life and thus result in more doors being opened for work opportunities. They present education and training as a viable route to an increase in women's engagement with politics, agency, and financial freedom, to drive poverty reduction and increase economic productivity, demonstrating the UN's link of women's empowerment to neoliberal agendas, and reflecting a wider link of mainstream development to equate economic improvements to empowerment (United Nations, 2023).

Conversely, Brown and Neve (2023) argue that skills-based initiatives consistently neglect everyday societal situations and the process of acquiring a skill, how it is disseminated, and then utilised. Therefore, this results in programmes that refuse to acknowledge intrinsic structural constraints, for example, gender and informal labour economies, that ultimately restrict a woman's ability to turn their skill into a stable livelihood (Brown and Neve, 2023). This disregard for how structures and societal norms impact who can attain and gain from skills initiatives. Such as the gendered components of labour within households, in addition to societal norms within communities that restrict a woman's ability to access employment after learning a skill.

Additionally, skills training must not be reduced to a purely economic or technical basis; it can also provide the opportunity for personal transformation, solidarity, and a sense of belonging (Brown and Neve, 2023). The ‘communities of practice’ theory posits that skills training results in an increase in self-esteem, confidence, personal and social identity, and purpose (Brown and Neve, 2023). This demonstrates how observing skill-training through a narrow-minded economic viewpoint negates the transformative nature of it, besides capital, thus skills-based training programmes should cultivate and promote these aspects beyond economic.

### *2.6 Women in Uganda*

Women contribute heavily to Uganda’s economy, yet this participation in the economy is impacted by the gendered division of the economy and labour, and social norms that routinely constrain women (Ellis, Manuel and Blackden, 2006). Furthermore, women’s ability to engage in the economy is heavily restricted by the burden of unpaid care work, for example, fetching water for themselves and their family, caring for their children and the household, which consequently fosters time poverty and mobility (Ellis, Manuel and Blackden, 2006).

Uganda has championed several gender transformative policies since 1986, including expanding educational opportunities, opening up access to the political sphere, and the formation of the Ministry for Gender Justice and Equality (Watson, Kyomuhendo, and Ghimire, 2020). Despite this, transformation has been uneven, and there are still significant barriers that women face in Uganda, with only 31% of women owning land or property, and inequalities in employment with high levels in the lowest-paying sectors of the economy and a 39% wage gap (Ellis, Manuel and Blackden, 2006).

Importantly, this increased shift of women’s participation in the economy in recent years has resulted in a further increased burden, with many women stating that an increase in income has subsequently decreased the male counterpart’s contribution within households (Ellis, Manuel and Blackden, 2006). Whilst women might be observed as becoming increasingly ‘empowered’ politically and economically, if their husbands do not support them, then there is an increased burden upon women. These tensions between structural constraints and economic participation reflect a wider necessity for transformation surrounding women’s liberation in Uganda.

## Chapter 3 Theoretical Framework: Post-colonial Feminist Approach

This dissertation intersects with post-colonial, feminist theories that emphasise the relational importance of empowerment, to critically observe the lived experiences of women in informal settlements in Uganda regarding empowerment, and to analyse how empowerment is practised within development in a real-life setting. I aim to contrast mainstream neoliberal conceptualisations of empowerment, which propagate capitalistic productivity and freedom of choice through economic freedom. Conversely, this research intends to re-centre the situated knowledge of women in these contexts, dissect the significance of the relational empowerment process, and demonstrate the structural barriers women still face.

### *3.1 Critiques of neoliberal empowerment*

Post-colonial feminist theory promotes the idea that operating within a relational framework results in a rejection of the mainstream neoliberal development agenda of economic growth, to valuing human connections and community solutions, and transforming gender norms through individual and collective dialogue (Tiessen, Lough and Laursen, 2021). These outcomes that are promoted tend to be overlooked by development initiatives that focus only on narrow economic metrics, but they are necessary for ensuring the process of empowerment, ensuring a bottom-up collective approach rather than a neo-liberal top-down intervention.

### *3.2 Epistemic injustice and marginalisation of voice*

At the core of post-colonial feminist theory, there is a critical application of the presumption that ‘the West’ is the key developer of theories and practical development interventions, whilst sidelining local situated knowledge (Spivak, 1988). Subsequently, the problematic conceptualisation of the ‘Third-World Women’ becomes apparent, consolidating these women into a homogenous, powerless group, which becomes presented as silent victims of socio-economic structures (Mohanty, 1988). This application of development tends to disregard women's cross-cultural experiences, leading to a form of epistemic violence, whereby local situated knowledge is ignored, and Western interventions are aimed at helping develop the ‘Other’ (Mohanty, 1988; Spivak, 1988). Thus, post-colonial feminist theory inherently rejects the idea that women living in the global South are a

homogeneous group that have the same aspirations and desires, but rather emphasises how women's experiences are constantly shaped by the role of class, religion, culture, and structures (Mohanty, 1988). Consequently, this dissertation aims to reject the idea that analysing empowerment based solely on economic metrics and Western-imposed ideals overlooks the deep complexities and different values of these women (Mohanty, 1988).

As Gayatri Spivak (1988) argues in his famous essay, "Can the Subaltern Speak?", the post-colonial feminist framework highlights the necessity of questioning voice, agency, and marginalisation within the global South. Spivak (1988) raises the important point of recognising and acknowledging how people who lie outside of mainstream power structures, such as women, become further marginalised within colonial contexts. Therefore, in this research, a post-colonial feminist framework is applied when looking at how empowerment is utilised in development. Whilst the importance of relational processes that reject a top-down approach, argued by Tiessen, Lough, and Laursen (2021), is evident, it is critical to question whether these development processes are still reflecting a Western viewpoint, as Spivak (1988) warns against, as this can lead to epistemic violence and Western frameworks remaining dominant.

### *3.3 Applying a post-colonial feminist framework to research*

Whilst there is literature critiquing empowerment on a conceptual level, there is a gap in qualitative research that specifically analyses the process in the specific development context of Uganda, whilst applying a post-colonial feminist theoretical framework. Therefore, this research aims to fill this gap by exploring how mainstream conceptualisations of empowerment manifest through development initiatives, particularly skill-building programmes, and how they compare to the lived experiences of women within informal settlements in Uganda.

Hence, post-colonial feminist theory provides an important framework for this research to critically analyse and evaluate how development programmes, even ones that present themselves as promoting feminist values, can fail to engage in the complex nature of cultural nuances, power structures, and the lived experiences of marginalised women. This framework will aid my analysis by providing a critical, culturally sensitive approach instead of focusing on simple neoliberal economic metrics. I will use this framework to recentre women's situated knowledge.

## Chapter 4: Research Aims and Objectives

### *4.1 Research Aims*

This dissertation aims to critically examine and analyse the concept and practice of women's empowerment within development, through the lived experiences of women living in informal settlements in Uganda, partaking in a skill-building programme offered by Kids Club Kampala. It aims to oppose mainstream neoliberal preconceived notions of empowerment through applying a post-colonial feminist framework and desires to give a voice back to marginalised women in knowledge production.

### *4.2 Research Objectives*

1. To examine how marginalised women partaking in development programmes, such as skills-based training, experience empowerment.
2. To investigate the limitations of structural barriers on empowerment to demonstrate the multi-faceted nature of the concept.
3. To delve into empowerment beyond mainstream neoliberal economic terms, researching the relational and collective nature of empowerment of marginalised women in Uganda.

## Chapter 5: Methodology

This chapter presents the feminist methodology implemented by this study, ensuring the recentring of the experiences and situated knowledge of women in informal settlements in Uganda, and rooting it within the inequality of institutions. The importance of rejecting universalist and Western dominant models of knowledge production was key, and the methodology made sure that marginalised women were the actors in creating their own knowledge production and was rooted in its social power (Mohanty, 1988; Haraway, 1988).

### *5.1 Research context*

This research is situated within the informal settlements of the capital city of Uganda, Kampala. The city was originally designed to host 300,000 people, but now it has grown to up to 1,680,600 people, with an additional daytime population of 4.5 million (Mukwaya, Mbabazi and Ernstson, 2025). Due to the rapid urbanisation, growth of the city, and

insufficient infrastructure, challenges arise. With a lack of infrastructure paired with rapid growth, the formation of informal settlements has increased tremendously. This results in a large informal sector, over 80%, which exacerbates youth unemployment, poverty, and inequality (United Nations Development Programme, 2023). Currently, there are around 62 informal settlements in Kampala, housing approximately 60% of the city (Hilton, 2024). These informal settlements are characterised by extreme poverty, with 38.9% of the population in Kampala living in severe poverty (UN Habitat, 2006).

Due to this environment, women face increased burdens and vulnerability, with high unemployment rates (Joy for Children Uganda, 2021). This research is in tandem with the skill-building programme provided by the organisation Kids Club Kampala, which works within 10 informal settlements in Kampala (Kids Club Kampala, 2025). This study was done in the Naguru informal settlement, where there is a built training facility for tailoring and knitting courses (Kids Club Kampala, 2020). This programme is designed specifically for “predominantly single mothers. To gain new vocational skills and start their own businesses [...] These programmes not only give women much needed income and skills, but they also help to empower them and build their sense of confidence, pride, and in general, a community. Hence breaking their cycle of poverty” (Kids Club Kampala, 2025).

### *5.3 Data Collection*

The data for this research were collected through a qualitative feminist methodology, with a focus on the lived experiences of empowerment of marginalised women in Uganda. In total, 17 interviews were conducted, all woman confirmed over the age of 18: 15 semi-structured interviews with, at the time of interviewing, current and graduated students of the skilling programme run by KCK in the Naguru Skilling Centre; 1 focus group was carried out with 3 women from the Kanyanya informal settlement who had graduated from the same programme that used to be implemented there but no is longer running; and 1 key informant interview with the KCK family strengthening project coordinator. For all interviews and the focus group, the project coordinator was the translator. However, most of the time, the women could speak English; therefore, at the start of every interview, the participant was asked what language they were most comfortable using for the interview, and if English was decided, the translators were present instead to provide translation if necessary.

*5.3.1 Semi-Structured Interviews*

Semi-structured interviews were selected as the main data collection process, due to their flexibility and ability to allow participants to provide new and differing ideas and perspectives of the topic at hand (Galletta, 2013). This aligned with feminist methodology and provided the space for marginalised women to frame their own experiences rather than being imposed on by neoliberal Western definitions, thus challenging dominant conceptions and practices of knowledge production that tend to marginalise and exclude subordinate groups, such as women (Saeidzadeh, 2023).

These interviews were taken at the Naguru Skilling Centre during either the morning or afternoon session, and throughout the interview, care was taken to make sure that the time of the women involved was respected. Being conscious of the fact that marginalised women's time in Uganda is often restricted due to household burdens, I worked in tandem with the programme coordinator to ensure that the interviews worked alongside their schedules at the programme. Being reflexive to the power dynamics of time aligns with a feminist methodology, which is committed to situated knowledge and challenges the masculinist, mechanistic approach to seeing interviews as purely a form of data collection, instead of a relational process (Oakley, 2016).

| Participant Code | Age | Marital Status | Child Status | Interview Length | Programme Status (at time of interview) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| IN1 | 25 | Married | 2 children | 24 | Attending |
| IN2 | 23 | Married | 1 child | 15 | Attending |
| IN3 | 23 | Single | None | 37 | Attending |
| IN4 | 19 | Single | None | 28 | Attending |
| IN5 | 26 | Married | 3 children | 30 | Attending |
| IN6 | 21 | Single | N/A | 22 | Attending |
| IN7 | 23 | Married | 1 child | 12 | Attending |
| IN8 | 68 | Married | 2 children | 43 | Attending |
| IN9 | 37 | Married | 6 children | 14 | Graduate |
| IN10 | 30 | Married | 3 children | 17 | Previous Graduate and Reattending |
| IN11 | 22 | Single | None | 10 | Attending |

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| IN12 | 21 | Single | 1 child | 33 | Attending |
| IN13 | 34 | Married | 3 children | 19 | Attending |
| IN14 | 32 | Married | 1 child | 10 | Graduate |
| IN15 | 74 | Widowed | 4 children | 48 | Graduate |

*Figure 1: Demographic characteristics of semi-structured interview respondents.*

### *5.3.2 Focus Groups*

Carrying out a focus group allowed the three women to come together to share their collective experiences and shared memories of the programme and empowerment as a whole, by talking together (Galletta, 2013). This aligns with the feminist methodology by challenging the dominant scientific approach that emphasises knowledge are an individual entity, but rather highlights that knowledge is relational and shaped through social interactions (Doucet and Mauthner, 2006). Ensuring that understandings of empowerment were rooted in the feminist methodology of recognising the cultural, economic, political, and social contexts of the data (Saeidzadeh, 2023). The benefits of focus groups within a feminist methodology are that they provide the opportunity for theoretical advances with the collective construction of meaning between groups of people; therefore, the women were able to come together to actively remember their time in the programme and to discuss what empowerment means to them and their community (Wilkinson, 1998). The one focus group carried out lasted 1 hour and 15 minutes in total; all women were graduates and married, and it will be referred to as code name: FG1, when referenced.

### *5.3.3 Key Informant interviews*

Key informant interviews give room for insight into the key participants who have a wide range of knowledge and experience within the research area, emphasising depth instead of breadth (Kibuacha, 2024). Thus, the key informant interview allowed for wider contextual understanding of the programme, the area, and the struggles faced by the programme and the women in it. It provided further insight into how the programme perceives empowerment and how it is implemented. Due to my positionality, some participants felt perhaps uncomfortable sharing the struggles they faced day to day with a white Western woman they had just met. Therefore, the key informant interview gave more depth to the research, as the project coordinator knew of the challenges that the women

face in this community. The interview lasted 37 minutes in total and will be referred to as code name: KI1, when referenced.

### *5.3.4 Field Observation Notes*

Field observation notes were implemented during the graduation day for the women taking part in the skilling programme. Allowing for documenting further contextual information and ensuring “rich context” to her aid deeper analysis into the women’s empowerment journeys (Phillippi and Lauderdale, 2017).

### *5.3.5 Sampling*

For the research study, participants were selected using purposive sampling to speak to women who were a part of the skilling programme currently or in the past that KCK offers, and the staff member who is directly involved in the programme. When selecting respondents from the programme, I worked closely with KCK and relied heavily on the project coordinator in selecting participants, as she works daily with the women and knows them personally.

## *5.4 Data Analysis*

The data collected from the interviews and the focus group were recorded on my phone and then transcribed using Otter.AI, and everything was rigorously checked for any errors. These transcripts were thereupon analysed on a thematic basis, first, generating codes from the data utilising the qualitative analysis software NVivo, whilst ensuring a postcolonial feminist framework was applied. To align with the framework, this process of analysis was not treated in a neutral sense but, importantly, as intertwined within my positionality and worldview.

## *5.5 Ethics*

Ethical approval was obtained from the University of Sheffield Ethics Committee before any research was done. Informed verbal consent was ensured prior to any of the interviews. The focus of the research was explained to participants, with translation

provided if necessary to fully understand the research. Participants were informed that every question was optional and reminded throughout that the interview was voluntary and that they could stop at any time if they so wished, additionally, that any information could be deleted if they desired. Anonymity was ensured by removing any possibly identifying information from the transcripts, and privacy was preserved by storing all transcripts on a password-protected laptop. Once the transcripts had been analysed, they were erased. I made the decision not to give the women pseudonyms and kept their anonymity through codes instead when referencing their words. As it can be argued that names are not just words but a part of people's identities and reflect their ethnolinguistic backgrounds and cultural legacies, and that renaming the women with Anglo-sounding names can perhaps neglect the women's distinctive identities, and potentially lead to further marginalisation by reinforcing stereotypes and power imbalance (Wang et al., 2024).

Due to the emotional nature of the research topic, particularly surrounding the constraints the women experienced and family conflict, I approached questions with sensitivity and care. I reminded all participants that they did not have to continue or answer anything if they were upset or uncomfortable. From a postcolonial feminist perspective, partaking in ethical research means that the knowledge production must be questioned, with a tendency for marginalised women to be exploited in the process. Thus, this research ethically aimed to avoid this epistemic violence but recentring the women's perceptions of empowerment instead of imposing Western narratives upon them.

### *5.6 Positionality and Reflexivity*

This study is committed to a post-colonial feminist framework; as such, reflexivity was a crucial part of the research process in order to continuously acknowledge my positionality and how I can ensure that there is no silencing of marginalised women's voices, and the recognition of situated knowledge as not a resource (Haraway, 1988). My position as a white, Western woman researching the experiences of marginalised women in Uganda brings along challenges, including the inherent power imbalance between researcher and respondent. Recognising and acknowledging this positionality is ethically important for this research in order to work against epistemic violence.

Throughout the entire research process, I remained aware of my personal background of privilege and ability to access resources that the women I was interviewing were unable to.

To engage with this, I ensured a relational approach was applied to the data collection process, following the feminist methodological idea that interviews should not be about extracting data, but creating and forming relationships (Oakley, 2016). To reduce these power imbalances, before and after interviews, I spoke to the women informally, asking them about their day and what they were getting up to at the programme. Furthermore, adopting a feminist methodology meant questioning how power imbalances also influence knowledge production and the analysis process; thus, I took a reflexive approach to the analysis of the data, how I interpreted it, and reminded myself of whose voices I was ensuring were heard (Doucet and Mauthner, 2006). Additionally, I kept a reflexive field journal that I wrote in every night, to bring intention to my research perspectives and assumptions throughout the research process (Olmos-Vega et al., 2022).

I also remained vigilant of the fact that I was working in tandem with KCK, even as an independent researcher, which could have impacted the interactions with respondents. Working alongside KCK, perhaps, could have indicated I was able to help with future opportunities, leading women to change their answers. Particularly, some women asked for financial support, how I was going to improve the programme, etc. To mitigate this best, I consistently reminded respondents throughout that I was completely independent from KCK, and that I was a student carrying out research; however, I recognise this may not have always been understood, thus demonstrating how my positionality affected the research process.

## Chapter 6: Findings, Analysis, and Discussion

### *6.1 The Limitations of Instrumental Empowerment*

#### *6.1.1 Skill Acquisition*

Learning a tangible skill was presented as a meaningful process for the women involved in the programme, with KCK facilitating this acquisition of new skills. Throughout the interview process, many women who had no prior knowledge or skill expressed how they have since gained a vocational skill. For example, one woman (IN1) stated, “I came without knowing anything about the skill, but now I feel I have something about the skill.” This attitude was reflected by another woman, who demonstrated the desire to learn, gain knowledge, and achieve personal accomplishment:

> “I wanted that skill. I wanted to have something interesting. [...] I thought about it, having the skill and having something in your head, you can start anytime, anywhere. So, I had to start.” (Focus Group)

These newly developed skills came alongside material gains, such as income and independence, with multiple participants recalling how they can now make their own money out of something with their own hands, and how that drew them to wanting to learn a skill:

> “I was like, no, I have to look for something that I can do with my hands, and I can do it by myself. So that’s why I joined here. I have so far started earning income out of the skill.” (IN10)

Beyond just economic and skill-based acquisition, many of the women described how acquiring a skill led to personal development, a sense of pride, and self-sufficiency. One woman (IN13) detailed how learning tailoring has provided her with a foundation to go off and achieve other things:

> “I have achieved a lot of things I did not know. I have learned how to sew, so when I leave this place, I am going to buy charts for different designs, I will be learning and sewing for other people.”

The pride that coincided with acquiring their newfound skill was evident, with the ability to make something with their own hands, in turn meaning that they have the potential to make income on their own:

> “Now I am proud I can make a sweater, I know I can survive the moment I step outside, I can do something from which I can get income.” (IN4)

> “I remember people asking, ‘Did you do that yourself?’ Because for those that know that I am a tailor, if I say yes, they say, ‘Please do this. Do you do it for me? Can you do this?’” (FG1)

This demonstrates how focusing on skill acquisition as the solution to improving poverty and increasing income, thus increasing self-sufficiency, mirrors the goals intended by KCK, as the project coordinator (KI1) described when asked what the goals of the programme were:

> “Because most of the women that we work with are single mothers [...] They didn’t go to school, so there is no chance of getting a proper job. So, one of the goals is that they skill you, and you are able to get a job or start up a business and get income and take care of your family.”

This highlights the perspectives of mainstream development discourses’ understanding of empowerment, where acquiring a skill is seen as the viable route to poverty reduction, productivity, and improved living standards. Directly reflecting Cornwall’s (2016) argument that instrumental empowerment becomes what women can do for development rather than the other way round, and focuses on a means to an end: economic growth. Whilst evident that gaining a skill provides women with increased opportunities for income and self-sufficiency, as shown in the following section, the limitations of emphasising individual capacity as an empowerment indicator are clear when intersecting with structural barriers.

### *6.1.2 Financial Constraints, Time Poverty, and Domestic Burdens*

On the surface, skill acquisition seemed positive for the women; however, many participants described challenges and limitations they still faced. The structural barriers of financial constraints, time poverty, and domestic burdens should be acknowledged and addressed instead of just focusing on the positive aspects of skill learning. This highlights an important argument within the limitations of instrumental empowerment, reflecting Khader’s (2018) proposed ‘control-choice’ framework, whereby women must have both the agency and the required resources to be able to make these choices, as demonstrated by the women who partook in this study; their choices were repeatedly and consistently constrained by structural barriers.

Many of the women detailed how difficult it was to ensure that they had an income whilst also being a part of the programme, as the programme was unpaid, and many had families they had to support. One participant (IN9) explained how her sister wanted to join but could not, “She wants to join, but the problem is time. The problem is time, and she needs to work.” Thus, reflecting the tension between learning a skill that provides the women with intended long-term benefits and the need for money to survive. This issue was further exacerbated by mothers, as the same respondent (IN9) with six children described the incredibly difficult process of trying to balance her domestic burdens with the skilling programme, as she stated:

> “It stresses me back because my kids, like at home, I have six children, but I have to drop them off at school. There was a challenge I had because of keeping time. Wake up early in the morning, take the kids to school, and come back in time for the programme. It was challenging. Sometimes I could be late.”

This reflects a clear example of time poverty, which is a concept that mainstream development initiatives tend to dismiss. The financial constraints directly intersect with domestic burdens and time poverty; they intertwine and come hand in hand. Many of the women explained the stress of meeting needs such as school fees and rent, which took away from their focus on learning their skills. This was made difficult further by the role of their husbands, as one woman (IN5) described, “My husband has never been supportive from the beginning to the end of the course; he has never come out to support me, which makes me feel sad.” The project coordinator (KI1) further explained that this lack of support from their husbands in turn increased domestic burdens, time poverty, and financial constraints:

> “The moment the husband gets to know that now the wife is earning, they leave all the responsibilities to the woman, which wasn’t the case before they started working.”

This directly aligns with the argument presented by Ellis, Manuel, and Blackden (2006), who state that in Uganda, once a woman starts earning, the household and financial responsibilities rest completely on her. This demonstrates the structural barriers that restrict women’s empowerment journeys.

### *6.1.3 Institutional Barriers*

Instrumental empowerment is heavily limited due to increased institutional and structural constraints. Further reflecting the contrasting discourse of governmental and structural rhetoric and the lived experiences of marginalised women in Uganda, highlighting the connection to the postcolonial feminist argument that empowerment based solely on economic metrics and Western-imposed ideals overlooks the deep complexities and different values of these women, instead viewing them as a homogenous group with the same goals and desires (Mohanty, 1988).

The project coordinator (KI1) expressed this when asked about how the government supports marginalised women in Uganda, “The accessibility. You might find that a government one is not so easy to access. The government have the funds for those projects, but it is so difficult to access.”

The supposed government programmes were promoted heavily during the time I spent at the graduation day for the women who had completed their 4 months in the training programme. This was due to a representative from the President’s office in Uganda being in attendance. Before she arrived, there was a positive focus on the women’s new skills and achievements; however, this differed once the representative arrived. The field notes I had written during the day demonstrate how the representative turned the graduation into a political spectacle, away from the women, towards an almost propaganda-esque campaign trail. My field notes reveal that the speech the representative made was promoting the programmes and money that the government are offering, turning the tone of the day into a bizarre competitive exhibition:

> “A lengthy speech on all the programmes and money the president has just waiting for the women to access easily.”

> “Made the women compete for money handouts [...] and if the women answered correctly, they would receive it.”

Yet, after graduation, I asked staff members in casual conversation about the speech the representative gave and the extent of how truthful she was about the available money and programmes they could access. The general sentiment was that this money was nearly impossible for any of the women to access. This offers a compelling depiction of a real-life example of how structural barriers, such as the Ugandan government, can depoliticise grassroots empowerment processes. It links back to Khader’s (2018) control-choice framework, whereby it is not just about how available the resource is, but the ability to access it, which is restricted by governmental bureaucracy. Moreover, this reveals how the neoliberal agenda of mainstream institutions further constrains marginalised women, rather than the government implementing real social change for women (Cornwall, 2016). The presence of the representative at the graduation provided an evident instance of the physical constraints that prevent marginalised women’s empowerment journeys, thus demonstrating the inherent limitations of instrumental empowerment.

### *6.2 The Process of Transformation*

#### *6.2.1 Confidence and Self-Worth*

Throughout the interviews with the women, the transformation of confidence and self-worth was incredibly evident, linking to Rowlands (1997) emphasis on transformational empowerment in opposition to instrumental empowerment, arguing that it should be a continuous process, not predefined outcomes, it should be experienced through deep personal change and transformation, and that every woman experiences this journey in separate ways. For a lot of the women, the programme and learning a skill provided an opportunity, shifting from a sense of hopelessness to one of pride and confidence:

> "The project has helped to give me confidence. In those days, I used to stay home. I felt so much, stressed, depressed, but I no longer feel that same way emotionally. Now it is like there is that emotional change." (IN1)

The sense of confidence depicted by the women came in many different forms, ranging from gaining a physical ability to produce something with their own hands but also from external validation. This aligns with Brown and Neve's (2023) theory of communities of practice, whereby skills training consequently increases self-esteem, confidence, personal and social identity, and purpose.

> "I remember that day we made trousers [...] and I went to church, and people were like, 'Wow, I love your trousers'. So, I'm really proud that I know how to make certain things right now. That really feels so good when you wear something nice. And people say, 'I'd love to have one like that.' That's really nice [...] I can do something that someone looks at and admires." (IN3)

This highlights the importance of relational empowerment, coinciding with Rowlands' (1997) argument that empowerment should increase women's self-confidence and self-esteem, sense of agency, and of 'self' in wider contexts, and most importantly, a sense of dignidad, which means feeling worthy and having respect from others. The women's self-perception shifting was observed throughout the interviews, with one respondent saying, "Within myself, I really feel I've changed, [...] now I can do something for myself. [...] I can

make for my children, my husband. [...] I really feel I got like a talent." (Interview 9) highlighting the importance of changing perception within in order to feel real change. Therefore, fostering these relational processes of empowerment, the self-perception of women taking part in the programme began to transform, allowing for internalised oppression to be easier to oppose (Rowlands, 1997).

### *6.2.2 Aspirations*

For the women, aspirations were an important part of their empowerment journey. Instead of seeing the skill as an immediate solution to changing their circumstances, it was rather perceived as allowing them the opportunity to think about the future, a luxury once not been thought of before. This coincides with relational empowerment, particularly the almost every woman interviewed expressed their desire to give back to their community and help other women learn a skill, rejecting the Western neoliberal agenda that emphasises individuality and productivity.

When talking about the future, the women rarely described in terms of increasing their income, but rather in increasing their independence: "I want to be someone who is independent. If I want something, I can get it on my own" (IN3). Another woman (IN5) stated, "I see my whole life improving, my standards of living improving". This links with Khader's (2018) control-choice framework, whereby increasing women's ability to make decisions further benefits their empowerment. Furthermore, within KCK, an aspirational desire for these women was evident, with the project coordinator (KI1) stating:

> "So, the big goals for the future of the project, [..] what I see is setting up a production unit for the women [...] who are unable to find employment, [...] we bring back alumni to work on those orders, [...] the income comes back to them." (Key informant interview)

These aspirations set out by the project coordinator reflect a deeper commitment to responding to the limitations of instrumental empowerment, financial constraints by attempting to provide an income for the women; however, without the wider structural changes, real social change for these women remains difficult.

### *6.2.3 Agency and Decision-Making*

The programme altered the women's sense of agency and decision-making abilities; however, it is important to recognise that these heightened abilities are within the context of the situated cultural context, and Khader's (2008) control-choice framework should be taken into consideration. The women described being able to do something for themselves and taking control of their lives, "I wanted to have a profession and not just sit there waiting for my husband to bring something to the table." (Focus Group) When being asked about how making decisions for yourself feels, one woman (IN9) responded:

> "It feels so good. At least I'm not waiting for my husband to provide for me. It feels really good to make your own money. Provide for yourself, provide for your kids."

However, when looking through the lens of the control-choice framework, expecting women to choose and do more leads to further disempowerment, and there are always incentives for them to do more as marginalised women and lift themselves out of poverty (Khader, 2008). As stated in *6.1.2 Financial Constraints, Time Poverty, and Domestic Burdens*, once the husband notices their wife is starting to earn income and gain agency, they withdraw support, leading to time poverty and added burden, as one woman (IN5) depicted:

> "[...] Husband has never been supportive from the beginning to the end. [...] I thought the husband didn't have money, but then later realised that he just didn't want to help me."

This highlights how increased agency and decision-making do not automatically lead to empowerment, with external constraints limiting it, aligning with Khader's (2008) control-choice framework, which looks at empowerment as an increase in agency and decision-making without acknowledging the conditions of poverty, women are left with having to choose between "bad alternatives". Further reinforcing the perspective from post-colonial feminist theory, that empowerment should not be an imposed ideal from a Western viewpoint, as marginalised women's agency is deeply rooted within their family obligations and poverty. Instead, the structures that produced their poverty to begin with should be fundamentally changed in order to create true lasting empowerment, as according to its original socially transformative meaning, based on rights and collective action (Eyben and Napier-Moore, 2009).

### *6.3 Collective Solidarity: Relational Empowerment*

#### *6.3.1 Sisterhood*

Arguably, the most important aspects of the women's journey through the programme were sisterhood, being key in practical, emotional, and financial support. This directly aligns with Rowlands' (1997) argument that empowerment should be recognised as relational, with change being a collective process, not one of individuality, as promoted by Western development discourse. The women in the programme described the practical support they received from each other, helping each other out by giving materials and fabrics, "When one has no material, you can help [...] I can give her my fabric for today, and then the other day, when I don't have she can give me also." (FG1). Another respondent (IN3) detailed the importance of moral support she received from the other women, "I love those who love me because they keep me pushing, having people give 'You can do it' 'No, you can face tomorrow' [...] anyone who [...] encourages me, tells, 'You know what, tomorrow will be better'. The programme became a haven for the women, "I feel like I'm at home" (Interview 9), where they received help, "If you don't know anything, you go to your friend [...] we are so cooperative" (IN15).

This emotional support provided by the women proved crucial in developing other aspects of the women's empowerment journey, for example, when one respondent (IN3) became ill for an extended period of time, the other women and teachers rallied around her to provide support, which felt "encouraging [...] thrilling [...] I felt accepted, I felt valued." This collective solidarity was developed further in their future community plans, with one woman describing (IN10) how they had created "community banking" groups just for women, where "we support ourselves, different skills, and we have to celebrate ourselves [...]" providing additional support via loans. The importance of these groups was evident, with her (IN10) stating:

> "You think like sometimes you may face something, challenges may come in life, and you think like, maybe my life is ending here, but when you join heads together, you find a solution, and you find something to do."

This provides compelling evidence of the importance of collective empowerment, with a bottom-up approach to helping the women against structural constraints, developed by the

women themselves, rather than being imposed by Western neoliberal development ideas, aligning with the post-colonial feminist framework's rejection of the mainstream neoliberal development agenda of economic growth, to one of valuing human connections and community solutions (Tiessen, Lough, and Laursen, 2021). As one participant (IN6) stated, "We always stay like sisters."

*6.3.2 Inclusion and Belonging*

According to the participants, the environment created by the programme was one of inclusion and belonging, which is essential when observing empowerment through a relational lens rather than through neoliberal economic measures of innovation, productivity, and income. Most importantly, the initiative did not discriminate against age, as the project coordinator (KI1) stated, "We have no age limit. [...] As long as they are interested in coming and learning a skill, they can come." This was evidently powerful for an older woman (IN8) who said:

> "I feel supported because I have tried in different projects, but I have been rejected because of my age. But here, I was accepted to come and learn. I was given a chance to come and be part of the initiative. Which is not the case everywhere I have tried."

This deliberate accessibility for marginalised women in the community fosters inclusion and belonging; it becomes a haven for the women who feel rejected by other mainstream programmes. Reflecting how relational empowerment with a more holistic approach becomes powerful in the women's journeys. As the women assert:

> "I feel like I'm at home. My teachers down there. They don't chase me. They always welcome me." (IN9)

> "First. When I came here, I was like, I even wanted to go back, because I was feeling that life was difficult for me. [...] but I even told that teacher [...] She always gives us advice, like, if you're doing something that's not good, she talks to us about missing school. She always talked to us. She loves us like, sometimes [...] I'm hungry. She always gives us something." (IN6)

> “Welcome? Yes, I had so much love here. [...] They welcome us so much, and they love us up to now, I’m not here, but they still love me.” (IN15)

This highlights how creating an environment of inclusion of belonging benefits the women’s transformational journeys, with the women going from feeling down to feeling loved and supported. The staff, importantly, were not just there to provide teaching, but to aid the women in the emotional aspects of the women’s lives, which are essential in focusing on empowerment beyond neoliberal predefined outcomes. The relational empowerment process is evident, with one respondent (IN15) stating, “In case of anything, I can always come back”. This idea of lasting connection to the programme, and the ability to come back for support, wholly rejects the mainstream idea of empowerment as a means to an end, as emphasised by Cornwall (2016), who criticises how increased development outcomes, such as innovation and growth, lead to empowerment losing its true transformative meaning.

*6.3.3 Community Support*

The women’s empowerment process was aided by community support, essential to ensuring relational empowerment is achieved, as Rowlands (1997) asserts, collective empowerment runs in tandem with individual empowerment, and participation within a group of women can further advance the process of personal empowerment and vice versa. The community supported the programme, offering a space for women to thrive.

One woman (IN5) described how “I don’t have support from my family, but I have support from the community”, and that she “told the local leader I didn’t have support, and then the local leader told me to [...] find something to do, get money and be part of this project.” Without the support of her community and the encouragement to go find something to do by the community leader, the respondent would not have furthered her empowerment, demonstrating how collective empowerment is essential alongside individual empowerment.

The community additionally helped support the women through financial means, as one woman (IN14) stated, “the community supports me because they bring me clothes to make uniforms or clothes to repair”, showcasing how community support provides a necessary

contribution to the women's empowerment journeys. Further practical support was provided by the community, as the project coordinator (KI1) explained:

> "The local leaders are truly, truly, very much supportive. [...] They are at the centre of the project. [...] They go around the community, advertising and encouraging women to come. [...] We have some local leaders who sponsor some of those women in terms of fabric."

Importantly, this community solidarity rejects the instrumentalist viewpoint of empowerment that furthers gains for the mainstream neoliberal agenda, which focuses on efficiency and growth (Eyben and Napier-Moore, 2009). However, as post-colonial feminist theorists, Spivak (1998) asserts that it is important to assess whether development processes are still inadvertently reflecting a Western viewpoint, which can lead to epistemic violence and Western knowledge hegemony. This can be addressed through the programmes' consistent dialogue within the community, and the grassroots nature of the initiative, evident through the earlier mention of the women's banking groups that have been created through providing a space for the women to meet each other and help one another.

*6.3.4 Peer-to-Peer Knowledge Transfer*

For many of the women, it was incredibly important to them to share their skills and knowledge with other women in their community, reflecting the importance of collective and transformative ideas of empowerment as a dynamic process (Rowlands, 1997). They pictured a future where they could improve their community directly from their knowledge and skills:

> "I wanted to do my own business such that also I teach some people who have never studied a course like me. [...] I want them to benefit like me." (IN11)

> "I believe there are so many women outside they are living in very, very poor standards. I would be supportive, extending my skills I have to them, and counsel them the same way I have." (IN4)

This demonstrates a form of local situated knowledge production, reflecting a post-colonial feminist theoretical perspective, whereby the women become active participants in

furthering their community, not in terms of income generation, but to become knowledgeable. This desire to teach others highlights how the women see the skill as a resource to uplift other women; instead of promoting Western neoliberal individualism, there is emphasis on valuing human connections and community solutions (Tiessen, Lough, and Laursen, 2021).

## Chapter 7: Conclusion

### *7.1 Concluding Remarks*

This study has critically analysed and demonstrated how marginalised women in Uganda experience empowerment within KCK's skilling programme, recentring their voices through the lens of postcolonial feminist theory. The findings showed that whilst skill acquisition was important and transformative, such as increasing pride, self-confidence, income, and agency, these benefits require acknowledging the ever-present constraints of additional burden, time poverty, financial barriers, and structural limitations. This reinforces Cornwall's (2016) arguments that instrumental empowerment focuses on economic outcomes and emphasises what women can do for development instead of what development can do for them. Instead of focusing solely on resource gains, this research demonstrates the relational aspect of empowerment, through the women describing their growth in self-worth, pride, and confidence, which were achieved not just individually but importantly through a collective network and shared solidarity. This further aligns with Rowlands' (1997) conceptualisation of empowerment as one of relational collective transformation, not just individual progress. Additionally, the women's desire to share their knowledge with other women and create support groups demonstrates a clear rejection of Western-imposed ideals, to focus on community solidarity, and a bottom-up approach, reinforcing the postcolonial feminist viewpoint of emphasising situated knowledge (Spivak, 1988).

### *7.2 Limitations of Research*

Naturally, the scope of this study was limited, whilst the 15 semi-structured interviews, one focus group, and a key informant interview provided rich data, they are unable to fully portray a wide diversity of marginalised women's lived experiences in Uganda. Moreover, the use of a translator and language barriers potentially changed how the women spoke or the interpretation of their words. Lastly, this study was done within a specific time in the

women's empowerment journeys; subsequently, a full understanding of long-term empowerment and structural limitations could not be completely investigated. However, this reinforces Haraway's (1988) understanding of situated knowledges and highlights the importance of how these findings should be understood as situated culturally, socially, economically, and politically.

### *7.3 Implications for Future Research*

This dissertation provides an opening for future research within the topic area. Firstly, further research could be done over an extended period of time to track empowerment and disempowerment processes through skilling programmes. Secondly, more research could be done to investigate how collective relational empowerment can be understood on a wider scale, perhaps internationally. Both future research ideas would contribute to rejecting narrow neoliberal economic framings of empowerment and recentre situated knowledge and the lived experiences of marginalised women globally. In doing so, this research can further contribute to debates surrounding the conceptualisation of empowerment, and importantly, to a more transformative and grounded outlook of development.

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